

The Proof of the Pudding: To Flourish for the Next Sixty Years

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THE PROOF OF THE PUDDING

TO FLOURISH FOR THE NEXT SIXTY YEARS

The follow-up is the great exposé of truth, the rock upon which fine theories are wrecked.

—P. D. SCOTT

In this chapter I will get down to particulars, showing exactly how longitudinal studies work, how they can be used, and why they matter so much. I will demonstrate in action how different this kind of information—that is, information derived longitudinally and prospectively—is from the other kinds of data so abundantly compiled through the “instruments” of social science. And I will illustrate our findings (as throughout the book) with both nomothetic (statistical) and ideographic (narrative) data.

In 2009, *The Atlantic* asked me to identify the most important finding of the Grant Study since its inception. 1 Without any official evidence to back me up, I answered rashly: “The only thing that really matters in life are your relations to other people.” This impulsive response was quickly challenged by a leading business weekly, which put it to me straight: What do romantic notions like that have to do with the real dog-eat-dog world? 2

Clearly I had dropped myself right into the middle of one of the oldest and most heated controversies in developmental studies: which matters more, nature or nurture? Is constitution or environment more important? Feelings have run high on this subject for a very long time, and here was an opportunity to bring some real evidence to bear on the matter. After forty years on the Study, did I have enough data to answer a make-or-break question?

At first I hoped to resolve the matter with a straightforward comparison. I would look at the lives of two groups of Grant Study men—one group that had been favored by nature with an enviable constitutional physical endowment, and another that had been favored by nurture with a loving childhood—and compare their lives fifty years later. This comparison had not been done before, and as it turned out I couldn’t do it in 2009 either, at least not precisely on those terms. Those two alternatives came out of different temporal universes, at least as far as the Study was concerned.

Remember, I was limited to data provided by the Study itself. The “nature” part was easy. In the 1940s, the Grant Study researchers were betting that a muscular, classically “masculine” body build could predict future success, and they had amassed a huge amount of information about the men’s physiques. It was a cinch to tell which men nature had favored, at least with regard to physical constitution. But the “nurture” part was a different story altogether. As I’ll detail in the next chapter, the Study originators weren’t thinking about tenderness and warmth as shapers of human lives. Personality researchers today give short shrift to physiognomy, and in the 1940s they didn’t ask about relationships. Environmental considerations were barely on their radar at all, let alone the nuances of family atmosphere. So it was much harder to discern which of those children had been lucky in love.

That was one problem. Another was obvious from the way the Australian Financial Review had responded to my venture: there are more opinions than one on what “matters.” Persuading twenty-first-century Wall Street types that love is all you need was going to be a hard sell.

But my appetite was whetted. Now I really did want to see what light the Grant data could shed on the nature/nurture battles, which meant reframing the issues (identifying success and identifying love) in terms that the available data could address.

So I devised a new question: Which best predicts successful old age: physical endowment, childhood social privilege, or early love? Then I set about defining explicitly the terms that would allow me to answer it. The problem raised by the

Australians was the first one to tackle: what counts as success? High school football stars are usually considered successful adolescents. But do the traits that make good quarterbacks also make good grandparents?

Eventually it occurred to me that while people can wrangle endlessly over whether the 400 meters or the high jump is the more challenging event, almost no one will deny that a person who scores high in a decathlon is a fine athlete. So instead of incurring the wrath of the Financial Review and who knows who else by settling on any single criterion, I established a Decathlon of Flourishing—a set of ten accomplishments in late life that covered many different facets of success. Then I set out to see how these accomplishments correlated, or didn't, with my three gifts of nature and nurture—physical constitution, social advantage, and a loving childhood.

This exercise, as I pursued it, proved an elegant demonstration of the power of prospective longitudinal material in general, and of the long-term perspective that gives it meaning. It also brought to the fore, and put into a larger context, many of the specific individual issues that the Study had been dealing with, and that I'll be addressing in detail in coming chapters. It served as a giant telescope, quickly bringing the big picture into focus, and clarifying decades worth of theoretical assumptions and disagreements. It's an ideal introduction, therefore, to this biography of the Grant Study.

THE DECATHLON

We all have our own definitions of what “flourishing” means, and of what makes life well lived and worth living. I covered as many of these as I could in my Decathlon of ten rewarding late-life outcomes—in accordance with my Olympic metaphor I'll call them events—that could be measured with some objectivity. I avoided abstractions like virtue, happiness, and self-actualization, and focused instead on concrete behaviors and achievements. Many readers, I'm sure, will object to at least some of the criteria I chose. But they were pragmatic choices, not dictated by taste, political correctness, or even principle. I had to be able to score the men's capacity to survive, to work, to love, and to play, and I had to be able to do it with data that were already on hand, so as to assure that I was exerting no control over the predictor variables of my three childhood conditions. I picked my ten events (that is, measurable achievements) as outcome variables because they were available. I had no advance knowledge of how they would correlate with the predictor variables. Some overlaps among the events, and some of the age limits that defined them, may seem arbitrary, but these too were enforced by the way the available data were collected and assessed, sometimes many years ago. As we go along, you'll become familiar with the kinds of questions we asked and the way we handled the answers. In the meantime, examples of our interview protocols are available for reference in Appendix A, and of our adjustment assessment schedules in Appendix D. The scales we used to assess childhood temperament and environment are in Appendix C. The background on how all this developed is in Chapter 3, which recounts the history of the Study.

Table 2.1 defines the Decathlon—the set of ten outcomes that I used to denote “flourishing.” The first two Decathlon events reflected occupational success: inclusion by age sixty in *Who's Who* in America and earned income in the top quartile of the Grant Study sample. I chose the former admittedly elitist criterion because almost all the men in the Study enjoyed high-prestige professions, and I needed a documented way to distinguish levels of achievement among them. Only 21 percent of the men were included in *Who's Who*. I recognized immediately that this distinction would favor writers, educators, politicians, and businessmen over doctors and lawyers. It took me longer to realize that the Decathlon did not adequately reflect the achievements of creative artists, however successful.

Table 2.1 A Decathlon of Flourishing, from Age 60 to Age 80 *

* The Decathlon was conceived to assess the men's success from 65 to 80, but all but one of the events could be estimated for the 14 men who died between 58 and 64 years of age, and therefore they were included. Men who died before their 58th birthdays, however, were excluded.

** The men were coded for the highest Eriksonian psychosocial task they had mastered (see Chapter 5).

The next four events reflected mental and physical health. Men who didn't need psychotherapy to cope with life's problems, or psychopharmaceuticals to relieve life's pains, were rated low for psychological distress. Event number four measured the men's enjoyment of work, love, and play between the ages of sixty-five and eighty (see Appendix D for how we measured this).

Events five and six reflected different aspects of biological success over time: being physically active (subjectively) at age seventy-five, and being physically and mentally healthy (both subjectively and objectively) at eighty. To meet the criteria for event number six required: that a man survive in good subjective and objective physical health to his eighty-first birthday; that at eighty he be without alcoholism, depression, chronic anxiety, or social isolation; and, finally, that he find subjective joy in many facets of his life.

Some readers may question my use of physical health as a Decathlon benchmark. Certainly longevity is not in itself a guarantee of flourishing. And while most of us would consider a happy and productive long life to be desirable, it is debatable whether an unhappy long life is better than a happy and productive short one. It's also true that a few vibrant and loving men received low Decathlon scores because they died young from genetic illnesses or chance events, while several inhibited men scored higher because they took few chances and lived a long, long time. Nevertheless, mental and physical well-being are integral to each other, and the challenge I had set for myself had to do with predicting success in old age.

The next four events reflected good relationships. The first was the achievement of Eriksonian Generativity (that is, the capacity for empathic nurturing of adolescents and adults other than one's own children; more on this in Chapter 5). The others were a happy marriage in late life, close father-child relationships in late life, and good social supports (friends, confidants, people to play tennis and bridge with, and so on) between the ages of sixty and seventy-five.

Some definition was necessary here, too. A man who had been happily married for most of the years between sixty to eighty-five was scored as having achieved this event even if there were five unhappy years and a divorce in the middle. In contrast, an intact thirty-five-year marriage was called "unhappy" if most of the time was spent in discord. (On these issues wives were consulted as well, separate from their husbands.)

Construing a variable as complex as good marriage as "present" or "absent" sounds simplistic, but in fact it was a pragmatic and useful device. It's very difficult to rank the relative happiness of marriages—your siblings', for example, or your three best friends'. But if both partners maintain over twenty years that their marriage is happy (which we scored as a 1), or if the state of their happiness is unclear to them during that time (scored as 2), or if their marriage is consistently rocky or they get divorced and never remarry (scored as 3), a three-point scale of marital happiness becomes plausible.

Throughout this book you'll see us transforming value judgments into science this way. What makes it possible is the availability of repeated measurements over time, one of the great strengths of longitudinal studies. And if these assessments can be defined and systematically derived with rater reliability—that is, if independent raters come to virtually identical scores—then it becomes possible to codify value judgments in a way that can be examined and tested statistically years or decades later, without the risk of their being altered or otherwise reinterpreted to suit an investigator's whim.

However annoying my sins of omission and commission, therefore, I hope my readers will agree that taken as a whole, doing well in the Decathlon is preferable to the alternative.

Although the ten variables that I employed to reflect flourishing appear disparate, they turned out to be, in fact, highly correlated with each other—that is, they tended to appear together—and up to a point this makes intuitive sense. Maintaining a high income and good social supports requires a certain amount of empathy and social intelligence; so does maintaining close family relations. Of forty-five possible correlations among the ten variables (that is, the forty-five different ways that ten variables can be paired) in Table 2.1, twenty-four pairs were very significantly correlated. Twelve more pairs were significantly correlated, and only nine pairs of correlations were not significant.

Please note, by the way, that throughout this book the word significant is used only in its statistical sense. Very significant (VS) refers to correlations for which the probability of their occurring by chance is less than one in a thousand; significant (S) refers to correlations for which the probability of occurring by chance is less than one in a hundred. Correlations significant at a level of $p < .05$ —that is, occurring by chance fewer than one time in twenty—are conservatively called not significant (NS).

SCORING

It's important to keep in mind that even though the Decathlon itself was not conceived until 2009, the data pertaining to the ten events I targeted for study were collected long before then, and usually during the time when the events were actually taking place. This is a prospective study, remember. The information that went into the Decathlon assessments came from the men's initial intake processing in 1938–1942, and from the extensive follow-up that succeeded it, up through the year 2009. All of these records were available to the scoring process, so judgments were made about a man's status based not on the fluctuating conditions of a single moment, but on information amassed over decades.

For every Decathlon event in which a man was in the top quartile of the Study sample, he received a point. If he had died before the assessment could be made, he received a zero in that event. Total scores, therefore, ranged from 0 to 10. A full third of the men scored 2 or 3; they were considered average on the flourishing scale. If we accept that this Decathlon does address, however imperfectly, several vital aspects of flourishing in late life, then the one-third of the men who received fewer than 2 points from most raters were living less desirable lives than the one-third of the men who scored 4 points or more. A cast of protagonists and their Decathlon scores can be found at the front of the book. Adam Newman received a midlevel Decathlon score of 2; Godfrey Camille, whom I will introduce shortly, received a 5. Of course, judgments about the “good life” can be very annoying. I had an academic partner once who challenged me for saying that Jack Kennedy was mentally healthier than Lee Harvey Oswald. Tastes differ.

ANTECEDENTS OF SUCCESS

Having established my criteria for success and scored the men on their achievement of them, I could now test statistically which of the myriad variables and traits that the Study had documented when the men were young—variables of nature and variables of nurture—could predict a good life in their later years.

In fact, to uncover the antecedents of flourishing had been one of the avowed purposes of the Study at its inception. Furthermore, the early years of data collection coincided with the early years of World War II, when efficient officer selection was very much on the minds of the investigators. Typical of the time, the original Study staff expected that the gift of leadership could be predicted by a particular constellation of constitutional endowments; this meant a mesomorphic (that is, athletic) and “masculine” (that is, narrow-hipped and broad-shouldered) body build. The staff used a study of ROTC recruits to justify this expectation retrospectively in 1945; in that study, 41 percent of the men with a strongly masculine physique were considered “excellent officer material,” while not a single man who was considered weak in the so-called masculine component was equally valued. However, there was no follow-up to document that these men actually made good officers, and as P. D. Scott implies in the epigraph of this chapter, that left this fine theory very much an open question. My intention was to pit the hard-nosed, body-build, nature values of the early Study investigators and the money-centered preoccupations of the modern business world against my own sentimental twenty-first-century values about the power of love. Which—constitution, money, or tender care—had the greatest power to predict success in the Decathlon of Flourishing? It's better to know than to believe, at least in matters of science, and it was time for conflicting beliefs to be resolved by facts.

Section A of Table 2.2 depicts ten characteristics, some physical and some not, that I chose to test as potential constitutional predictors of a rewarding late life. The first six had been thought likely suspects by the original Study staff, especially for predicting future officers and store managers. (This was a high priority of William Grant, the chain-store impresario who funded the Study and gave it his name; more about Grant and the first four characteristics in Chapter 3.) They were: vital affect (a rich, exuberant social presence), sociability, masculine body build (narrow hips, broad shoulders), mesomorphy (muscularity), treadmill endurance, and athletic prowess. To these I added four other constitutional or biological factors: childhood temperament (see Chapter 4), hereditary loading for (that is, family history of) alcoholism and major depression, and longevity of parents and grandparents.

I also included three variables to test the effect of socioeconomic status on the men's future. Parental social class was assessed by paternal income, occupational status, neighborhood, and a home visit. The education of each parent was also assessed.

That done, the Australian challenge could no longer be avoided. And this brought me straight back to my initial problem, the one that had foiled my simple group-to-group comparison and driven me to Olympic elaborations. Namely, there were no data available—the Study had collected no data—that directly addressed the amount or quality of the love that the College men had received as children.

Table 2.2 What Variables Predict a High Decathlon Score at Age 60–80?

Very significant = $p < .001$; Significant = $p < .01$; NS = Not significant.

* “Items” refers to the number of Decathlon events predicted significantly by the antecedent variable.

** See Chapter 8 .

I had to find a way to test definitively my impulsive assertion that warm intimate relationships are the most important contributing factor in the establishment of a good life. Relational warmth is tough to measure even in the twenty-first century, and we’ve been working on it for a long time. In 1940 no one had even put forth the concept of attachment, certainly not the biometric psychologists or the Freudian psychoanalysts to whom the Study first gave ear. But more on that later. What matters here is that only four objective measures of relationship skills had been gathered before the measures of Decathlon success were obtained, so I had to content myself with those. They became my third set of predictors.

The men and their parents were not accessible to the Study until the men were in college, at which time both men and parents were interviewed in depth. These interviews were the first indicators the Study had of the men’s early home life, and of their relationships with their parents and siblings—obviously important predictive variables. Yet the men’s childhood environments were not assigned nuanced numerical scores at the time they were assessed; that was done only after I joined the Study. (I will describe our after-the-fact scoring of the men’s childhoods in Chapter 4 .)

The second relational predictor was the Study staff’s consensus rating (as the men finished their senior years at about age twenty-one) of the men’s overall “soundness.” That rating had been based on a 1-to-3 scale as follows:

1 = A man seen as without “serious problems in handling problems that might confront them.”

2 = A man seen as “lacking in warmth in his touch with people,” or too “sensitive.”

3 = A man seen as “markedly asocial,” or manifesting “marked mood variations.”

The third predictor was the maturity or immaturity of the men’s involuntary coping style (perhaps better known as defensive style) between ages twenty and thirty-five. This was assessed by me retrospectively when the men were forty-seven from information provided earlier (retrospective data analyses are permissible in a prospective study; retrospective data are not). This too will be explained more fully (in Chapter 8); keep in mind that this chapter is a sketch, a roadmap of terrain that we will cover in more detail later on. For now, what matters is that our defensive styles influence our relationships. Mature coping (sometimes called defense) mechanisms like humor and patience tend to attract other people; immature coping mechanisms like projection and hypochondriasis, while temporarily soothing to their users, appear self-centered to other people and tend to alienate them.

The final predictor was warm adult relations between ages thirty and forty-seven. Although this variable was not assessed until 1975, when the men were in midlife, we included it because there really were no earlier objective variables reflecting capacity for close attachment. This crude scale asked six objective, if simplistic, yes-or-no questions:

- Had the man been married for more than ten years?
- Was he close to his children?
- Did he have close friends?
- Did he maintain pleasant contact with his family of origin?
- Did he belong to social organizations?
- Did he play games with others?

WHAT VARIABLES PREDICT SUCCESS?

Table 2.2 sets out the seventeen variables that we tested for their power to predict flourishing late in life—ten constitutional variables that recreated the worldview of the early investigators, three socioeconomic variables that recreated the worldview of modern social psychology (and possibly the Australian Business Review), and finally the

four available relational variables that reflected the view of attachment theorists and ethologists. I admit readily that these were sketchy, but they were the only ones available to us; any measures of relationship that post-dated the Decathlon would of course not be predictive. The table also indicates how each variable associated with the total Decathlon score.

As the table indicates, the ten constitutional variables and the three social variables were of limited predictive use. The two manifestations of the body-build hypothesis so beloved of the original researchers had no significant correlation at all with later success. Nor did the measures of socioeconomic status. Alcoholism and depression in family histories proved irrelevant to Decathlon scores at eighty, as did longevity. The sociable and extraverted personality type that was so esteemed in the Study's selection process (see Chapter 3) did not correlate with later flourishing either. (We'll see in the last chapter, though, that Extraversion when measured by a sophisticated psychological "instrument" did prove very significant.) In fact, of the thirteen constitutional/socioeconomic factors that we tested for their predictive strength, only four correlated significantly with the total Decathlon scores, and those only with one or two events apiece. The correlations between the constitutional and socioeconomic variables and Decathlon success were weak and scattershot.

The four measures of relationship, however, were all highly predictive of Decathlon success. Each of these four variables predicted at least six events apiece, and collectively they predicted all ten. Furthermore, each relationship predictor correlated highly significantly with the other three, suggesting that they had something in common. In short, it was the capacity for intimate relationships that predicted flourishing in all aspects of these men's lives, as can be seen in Table 2.3 .

Table 2.3 Childhood Predictors of Flourishing in Old Age

Very Significant = $p < .001$; Significant = $p < .01$; NS = Not Significant.

Here's a concrete example, to make these abstractions a little more vivid. We found, for instance, that there was no significant difference between the maximum earned incomes of the men with IQs of 110–115 and the incomes of the men with IQs of 150-plus. Nor was there a significant difference between the maximum earned incomes of men with mesomorphic (muscular) physiques and men with ectomorphic (skinny) or endomorphic (plump) physiques, or between men with blue-collar fathers and men with fathers from the upper class (Table 2.2).

On the other hand, the men who had good sibling relationships (one factor of a warm childhood; see Table 2.2 and Appendix C) when young were making an average of \$51,000 (in 2009 dollars) more a year than the men who had poor relationships with their siblings, or no siblings at all. The men from cohesive homes made \$66,000 per year more than men from unstable ones. Men with warm mothers took home \$87,000 more than those men whose mothers were uncaring. The fifty-eight men with the best scores for warm relationships were three times more likely to be in Who's Who, and their maximum income—between the ages of fifty-five and sixty, and in 2009 dollars—was an average of \$243,000 a year. In contrast, the thirty-one men with the worst scores for relationships earned an average maximum salary of \$102,000 a year. The twelve men with the most mature coping styles reported a whopping \$369,000 a year; the sixteen men with the most immature styles a much more modest \$159,000. These same variables were equally able to predict warm relationships at the end of life.

So my rash contention held up. Nurture trumps nature—at least for predicting late-life success as the Decathlon embodied it. And the aspect of nurture that is most important of all is a warm and intimate relational surround (environmental childhood strengths, Appendix C). There is another piece to be reckoned with too. In a moment I will offer a life story to illustrate it, and what these actualities look like in the real world. But first let me offer one caveat, and then an illuminating historical aside.

The caveat: Throughout this book I will seem to be saying that the mentally healthy have better characters than the mentally unhealthy. This sounds like victim-blaming, but it is not a moral judgment. It is a reflection of a tough and pragmatic reality: that empathy is easier for those with full (literally and figuratively) stomachs. Someone who is already suffering the stresses of (literal and figurative) hunger is more likely to respond self-protectively or to lash out when punched in the gut.

The historical aside: I was chary from the beginning of the body-build approach to prediction, and of some of the other cherished hypotheses from the early days of the Study. Remember that in the thirties and forties constitutional medicine and physical anthropology were very much in the theoretical driver's seat; it wasn't only in Germany that

people were preoccupied with the fine points of putative racial superiorities. But since the data were so extensive, and since I was in the neighborhood anyway while constructing the Decathlon, I decided to test out the relationship, so confidently assumed at the time, between officer potential and body build.

At the end of World War II, some of the Grant Study men were majors; others were still privates. What made the difference? It turned out that the men's attained military rank at discharge bore no relation to their body build, their parents' social class, their endurance on the treadmill, or even their intelligence. What did correlate significantly with attained military rank was a generally cohesive home atmosphere in childhood and warm relationships with mother and siblings. Twenty-four of the twenty-seven men with the warmest childhoods made at least first lieutenant, and four became majors. In contrast, of the thirty men with the worst childhoods, thirteen failed to make first lieutenant, and none became majors. We don't breed good officers; we don't even build them on the playing fields of Eton; we raise them in loving homes. This result would undoubtedly have astonished physical anthropologist Earnest Hooton (see Chapter 3), whom the Study asked to write its first book. 4

I offer this story for its morals. One is that belief isn't enough—however impassioned our convictions, they need to be tested. Another is that information does nothing for us if we don't make use of it. My brief excursion here answered a question that the Study had been entertaining from its very beginnings; the data that finally answered it had been available for almost seventy years. And a third: that longitudinal studies protect us from exactly such pitfalls, and from our other shortcomings of foresight and method. They give us the flexibility to re-ask old questions in new contexts, and to ask new questions of old data. That is a very important point of this book, and one I'll keep returning to.

THE LIFE OF GODFREY MINOT CAMILLE

Now let me abandon statistics and present some idiographic evidence for the power of love; a life is worth a thousand numbers. In 1938, when Godfrey Minot Camille first presented himself to the Grant Study, he was a tall redheaded boy with a charming manner who planned to enter medicine or the ministry. Only gradually did the staff discover that the allegedly "normal" Godfrey was an intractable and unhappy hypochondriac. On the tenth anniversary of his joining the Study, each man was given an A through E rating anticipating future personality stability, and when it was Godfrey's turn, he was assigned an "E." But if Godfrey Camille was a disaster as a young man, by the time he was an old one he had become a star. His 5 on the Decathlon put him in the top quartile of the surviving men of the Study. What made the difference? How did this sorry lad develop such an abundant capacity for flourishing? He spent his life searching for love.

Camille's parents were upper class, but they were also socially isolated and pathologically suspicious—both of them; social privilege did not predict the warmth, or the chill, of a man's childhood. "Mother hasn't exactly made up for Dad's shortcomings," Camille put it at nineteen. At forty-six, he sadly reaffirmed a truth he had recognized earlier: "I neither liked nor respected my parents." Lewis Gregory, the Study's family interviewer, described Mrs. Camille as "one of the most nervous people I have ever met . . . a past mistress in self-deception." A child psychiatrist who reviewed Camille's record thirty years later thought his childhood one of the bleakest in the Study. (Evidence used in these assessments rarely came from just one source.)

Unloved and not yet grown into a sense of autonomy, Camille as a student adopted the unconscious survival strategy of frequent visits to the college infirmary. No evidence of tangible illness was found at most of his visits, and in his junior year a usually sympathetic college physician dismissed him with the disgusted comment, "This boy is turning into a regular psychoneurotic." Camille's constant complaining was an immature coping style. It didn't connect with other people, and it kept them from connecting with him; they didn't see his real suffering and just got angry at his apparent manipulations.

When the war began, Camille was destined for failure, at least by Study criteria. He was an ectomorph, skinny and without the broad shoulders and narrow hips that might have redeemed his scrawniness as "masculine." His athletic conditioning was poor, and he hadn't done particularly well in college academically. He would have been doomed by my criteria, too. He had had the worst possible childhood, he used unempathic coping styles, and he seemed clumsy at human relations. To no one's surprise, he emerged from World War II still a private—everyone had predicted he would be a loser. So, a little later, did I.

After graduation from medical school, the newly minted Dr. Camille made a suicide attempt. The Study consensus at the time of his ten-year personality assessment was that he was “not fitted for the practice of medicine,” and, unloved as he was, he found taking care of other people’s needs overwhelming. But several sessions with a psychiatrist gave him a different view of himself. He wrote to the Study, “My hypochondriasis has been mainly dissipated. It was an apology, a self-inflicted punishment for aggressive impulses.”

Having grasped that he was paying for anger with depression, Camille abandoned his hypochondriacal defense and the unconscious purpose it served for a more mature coping mechanism—displacement. He learned to shift his attention away from uncomfortably intense emotional issues toward more neutral ones. When his sister died, he sent the Study the autopsy report with the simple comment, “Enclosed is a copy of an autopsy protocol, which I expect is also an item of news.” He never mentioned his feelings about her death, or even the fact of it. He did not tell the Study directly about his mother’s death either, but—displacing his attention from heart to brain—wrote cryptically, “I received an inheritance from my mother.” Whatever the limitations of this approach, it was a more empathic one than his hypochondriasis had been; whereas people had once felt overwhelmed, helpless, and angry in the face of his constant physical complaints, they now found him much more comfortable to deal with.

For all his adolescent hypochondria, Camille hadn’t really been very aware either of his body or of his feelings. He felt things, yes. But what he was feeling—a symptom of illness? an upsurge of anxiety? a chimerical fantasy?—was not a distinction he knew how to make. Under stress he had sensations, and he felt that they required immediate attention. After his post-suicidal insight at thirty-two, however, he began to distinguish between physical and emotional sensations, and to pay attention to their causes. Emotional stress still led to indigestion, abdominal pains, cold hands, and gastric distress, but Camille no longer insisted to physicians that he was ill, or used his physical complaints to convey his outraged sense of need or hold someone else responsible for it. Instead, after psychotherapy, he used his physical symptoms as a clue to the presence of emotional distress.

Then, at age thirty-five, he had a life-changing experience. He was hospitalized for fourteen months in a veterans’ hospital with pulmonary tuberculosis. Ten years later he recalled his first thought on being admitted: “It’s neat; I can go to bed for a year, do what I want, and get away with it.” “I was glad to be sick,” he confessed. And in fact that illness, a real one, ended up giving him the emotional security that his childhood, his hypochondriacal symptoms, and his subsequent careful neutrality never had. Camille felt his time in the hospital almost like a religious rebirth. “Someone with a capital ‘S’ cared about me,” he wrote. “Nothing has been so tough since that year in the sack.”

Released from the hospital, Dr. Camille became an independent physician, married, and grew into a responsible father and clinic leader. Over the next five years he mastered the adult developmental tasks of Intimacy, Career Consolidation, and Generativity (see Chapter 5) in rapid succession. His marriage, which lasted for more than ten years but was not particularly happy, finally ended in divorce. But one of his daughters at fifty told me in an interview that his children remembered him as an exemplary father.

Camille’s coping style was changing as the decades passed, too. His transitional reliance on displacement (the unconscious avoidance of emotional intensity) was replaced by the still more empathic involuntary coping mechanism of altruism, including the generative wish to nurture others’ development. He was now functioning as a giving adult. Whereas at thirty he had hated his dependent patients, by forty his adolescent fantasy of caring for others had become a reality. He started and directed a large Boston clinic for allergic disorders—the first time he had ever been in charge of anything. He wrote papers to help other clinicians understand and deal with the emotional needs of asthmatic patients with deprived childhoods. In vivid contrast with his post-graduation panic, he now reported that what he liked most about medicine was that “I had problems and went to others, and now I enjoy people coming to me.” His daughter told me when I met her that “Dad had the innate ability to just give. He could play like five-year-olds do.”

When I was fifty-five and Camille was almost seventy, I asked him what he had learned from his children. “I haven’t stopped learning from them,” he said. He seemed to appreciate that that was a facile answer, and added thoughtfully, “That’s a tough question. . . . Isn’t that a whopper!” I was disappointed; I had felt sure that this sensitive man would come up with a more profound response. But two days later he came up to me in Harvard Yard as I was about to give a talk to his reunion class. With tears in his eyes he blurted out, “You know what I learned from my children? I learned love!” Many years later, having seized a serendipitous opportunity to interview his daughter, I believed him. I have interviewed

many Grant Study children, but this woman's love for her father remains the most stunning that I have encountered among them.

When I first wrote about the life of Godfrey Camille, I had no idea what had led to his recovery. Clearly it had been catalyzed by his year of enforced invalidism, but how? At age fifty-five, he attributed everything to a visit from Jesus at the hospital; I myself (at forty) was inclined to think that it was all the loving nursing care he had received over those many months. But neither was a very satisfactory explanation. What I know now is that it doesn't really matter. It took me many more years of prospective follow-up, and many more years of emotional growth, to learn to take love seriously. What it looks like—God, a nurse, a child, a good Samaritan, or any of its other guises—is different for everybody. But love is love.

At age seventy-five, Camille took the opportunity to describe in greater detail how love had healed him. This time he needed no recourse to Freud or Jesus.

Before there were dysfunctional families, I came from one. My professional life hasn't been disappointing—far from it—but the truly gratifying unfolding has been into the person I've slowly become: comfortable, joyful, connected and effective. Since it wasn't widely available then, I hadn't read that children's classic, *The Velveteen Rabbit*, which tells how connectedness is something we must let happen to us, and then we become solid and whole.

As that tale recounts tenderly, only love can make us real. Denied this in boyhood for reasons I now understand, it took me years to tap substitute sources. What seems marvelous is how many there are and how restorative they prove. What durable and pliable creatures we are, and what a storehouse of goodwill lurks in the social fabric. . . . I never dreamed my later years would be so stimulating and rewarding.

That convalescent year, transformative though it was, was not the end of Camille's story. Once he grasped what had happened, he seized the ball and ran with it, straight into a developmental explosion that went on for thirty years. A professional awakening and a spiritual one; a wife and two children of his own; two psychoanalyses; a return to the church of his early years—all these allowed him to build for himself the loving surround that he had so missed as a child, and to give to others out of its riches.

More years passed. At seventy-seven, Camille was viewing his past five years as the happiest in his life. He had a new love; he was whipping men thirty years his junior at squash; he was nurturing a beautiful garden. He was also deeply involved in the community at Trinity Church. Perhaps I had been wrong to dismiss his hospital trust in a loving Christ so offhandedly.

At eighty, Camille threw himself a potluck supper birthday party. Three hundred people from his church came. He provided the jazz band.

At eighty-two, Godfrey Minot Camille had a fatal heart attack while climbing in the Alps, which he dearly loved. His church was packed for the memorial service. "There was a deep and holy authenticity about the man," said the bishop in his eulogy. His son said, "He lived a very simple life, but it was very rich in relationships." Yet prior to age thirty, Camille's life had been essentially barren of relationship. Folks change. But they stay the same, too. Camille had also spent his years before the hospital looking for love. It just took him a while to let himself find it.

By the time Godfrey Minot Camille was eighty, even Aristotle would have conceded that he was leading a good life. But who could have foreseen, when he was twenty-nine and the Study staff ranked him in the bottom 3 percent of the cohort in personality stability, that he would die a happy, giving, and beloved man? Only those who understand that happiness is only the cart; love is the horse. And perhaps those who recognize that our so-called defense mechanisms, our involuntary ways of coping with life, are very important indeed—the missing piece I mentioned above. Before age thirty, Camille depended on narcissistic hypochondriasis to cope with his life and his feelings; after fifty he used empathic altruism and a pragmatic stoicism about taking what comes. There are two pillars of happiness revealed by the seventy-five-year-old Grant Study (and exemplified by Dr. Godfrey Minot Camille). One is love. The other is finding a way of coping with life that does not push love away. And that is why I offer Dr. Camille's story as a sort of outline of the terrain we'll be covering through the rest of this book.

CONCLUSION

Pictures are worth a thousand words, but sometimes they speak more to the passions than to reason. Numbers don't lie, but sometimes they do. Together, however, pictures and numbers can keep each other honest, and that is why I offer in this book a bifurcated exposition of what appear to me (so far) to be the ultimate (so far) lessons of the Grant Study.

One is that positive mental health does exist, and to some degree can be understood independent of moral and cultural biases. But for this to happen, we must acknowledge our value judgments and define them operationally, and we must prove the validity of our definitions not by persuasive argument, but by documented outcomes. This is important. Eighty years ago it was common to hear Hitler and Stalin called great leaders, and Churchill dismissed as a disastrous failure of a statesman. It will be another eighty years before we'll be able to rank realistically the leadership skills of Presidents Nixon, Reagan, Clinton, Bush father and son, and Obama. In presidencies, in studies, and in lives, the proof of the pudding is in prolonged follow-up—not for years, but for decades. More on this throughout the book, but especially in Chapter 7.

The second lesson is that once we leave the study of psychopathology for positive mental health, an understanding of adaptive coping (explored in Chapter 8) is crucial. As in the inflammations and fevers of physical illness, what looks like trouble may be the very process by which healing takes place. As we become better able to endure life's slings and arrows, our coping mechanisms mature, and vice versa.

The third lesson is that the most important influence by far on a flourishing life is love. Not early love exclusively, and not necessarily romantic love. But love early in life facilitates not only love later on, but also the other trappings of success, such as prestige and even high income. It also encourages the development of coping styles that facilitate intimacy, as opposed to ones that discourage it. The majority of the men who flourished found love before thirty, and that was why they flourished. I will discuss some of the vicissitudes of intimacy in Chapter 6.

But—this is the fourth lesson—people really can change, and people really can grow. Childhood need be neither destiny nor doom, as Chapter 5 will make clear. So does the story of Dr. Camille, a model of posttraumatic growth.

Lessons Two, Three, and Four are closely related. Throughout our lives we are shaped and enriched by the sustaining surround of our relationships. The seventy-five years and twenty million dollars expended on the Grant Study points, at least to me, to a straightforward five-word conclusion: "Happiness is love. Full stop." Virgil, of course, needed only three words to say the same thing, and he said them a very long time ago—*Omnia vincit amor*, love conquers all—but unfortunately he had no data to back them up. 5

A fifth lesson, to be expanded in Chapter 4, is that what goes right is more important than what goes wrong, and that it is the quality of a child's total experience, not any particular trauma or any particular relationship, that exerts the clearest influence on adult psychopathology. Consider Camille's "year in the sack." Let me repeat myself: what goes right is more important than what goes wrong.

A sixth lesson is that if you follow lives long enough, they change, and so do the factors that affect healthy adjustment. Our journeys through this world are filled with discontinuities. Nobody in the Study was doomed at the outset, but nobody had it made, either. Inheriting the genes for alcoholism can turn the most otherwise blessed golden boy into a trainwreck (Chapter 9). Conversely, an encounter with a very dangerous disease liberated the pitiful young Dr. Camille from a life of dependency and loneliness.

The final lesson is that prospective studies really do elucidate life's mysteries. I've given only a tantalizing taste of this lesson in Chapter 10, because it really does involve mysteries, and we are a long way from solving them in full. Yet it is likely that when they are solved, it will be with the help of lifetime studies like this one. The Grant Study has given us seventy-five years of real behaviors—not just trues and falses, not just A, B, C, D, or none-of-the-aboves—on which notions old and new about a rewarding life can be tested, retested, and refined.

Even as they first set out, the originators of the Grant Study were beginning to gather exactly the evidence that contrarians like me would need to disagree with them. I inherited an orchard planted and nurtured with great care by a group of dedicated gardeners. For forty years I harvested its yield and took it to market. And since it is on follow-up that our theories stand or fall, my successors will continue the harvest when I no longer can. But credit for the fruit goes back to Arlie Bock, Clark Heath, and Lewis Gregory Davies who gave it the place and the time to grow, and to Charles McArthur who fertilized and pruned it once they had hung up their trowels. The creation of the Study is a life story all its

own, and in the next chapter I will tell it.